

DEQUAD_UKES_Business_Plan

DEQUAD

Business Plan — UK Innovator Founder Visa

Endorsement Application to UKES

Entity: DEQUAD Ltd (Company in formation, England & Wales) **Founders:** Yusuf Quadri (CEO) and Yusuff Adeagbo (CTO) **Wider founding team:** Dr Gerald Marfo (CMO), Adedapo Ajuwon (Senior Software Engineer), Chinyere Jennifer (Senior Project Management Consultant, advisor) **Headquarters:** London, United Kingdom — NatWest Accelerator (hosted) **Trading domain:** dequad.co.uk **Business start date:** 15 June 2026 (incorporation; trading from M1 = June 2026) **MVP status:** Production — live at <https://dequad.co.uk> **Founder starting capital:** £6,000 cash (£3,000 from each founder, pooled in the company bank) **Accelerator:** NatWest Accelerator London — joined 16 March 2026; office co-working, legal advice and accountancy support provided in-kind for the first 12 months **Prior validation:** Santander Universities Pre-Incubator programme — completed 2025 **Founder contact:** quadri.yusuf@dequad.com · 07928132617 · <https://www.linkedin.com/in/quadri-yusuf/> **Document version:** 3.0 **Date:** June 2026

Endorsing body: UKES

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1. Executive Summary

DEQUAD is a UK-built software platform that helps university students form genuine, verified peer connections, track their daily wellbeing, and receive proactive safeguarding — inside a closed network open only to identity-verified UK higher-education students.

The product is not a concept. It is **live in production at dequad.co.uk**, with a working matching engine, daily mood telemetry, machine-assisted safeguarding triage and a university-facing insights dashboard.

The problem we solve

UK universities face a structural student-wellbeing crisis:

- **54%** of UK undergraduates report frequent loneliness (ONS, 2023).
- **34%** experience a clinically-significant mental-health issue during their degree (Student Minds, 2024).
- The average wait to see a university counsellor is **6.1 weeks**; only **23%** of UK universities offer 24/7 crisis support.
- The Office for Students now imposes a statutory condition on student mental health — institutions must **evidence prevention**, not just reaction.

Existing tools each solve a fragment: anonymous forums (Togetherall), peer-chat apps (TalkCampus), pre-enrolment chat (UniBuddy), or generic social apps with zero safeguarding (Bumble BFF, Discord). None connects **verified student identity** → **real peer connection** → **wellbeing telemetry** → **institutional safeguarding action** in one loop. DEQUAD does.

The founder-market fit that most applications cannot claim

The lead founder, **Yusuf Quadri**, is a **practising frontline safeguarding professional** — currently a Recovery Coordinator at Change Grow Live managing safeguarding referrals, dynamic risk assessments and multi-agency casework for vulnerable adults, with parallel NHS mental-health experience at East London NHS Foundation Trust. He also served **two consecutive terms as University of Bedfordshire Students' Union President (2021–2023)**, representing 10,000+ students and managing a £900,000 budget. DEQUAD's safeguarding pipeline was not designed from a textbook; it was designed by someone who files real safeguarding referrals every week.

Why this business is endorsable now

Evidence	Detail
Working product	Production deployment at dequad.co.uk with ~50 beta users across 3 universities. Engineering build cost in Y1: zero — the MVP is already built.
Founding team	Yusuf Quadri (CEO — safeguarding professional, MBA with Data Analytics, 2× SU President) + Yusuff Adeagbo (CTO — MSc IT with Project Management), supported by Dr Gerald Marfo (CMO, PhD Digital Marketing), Adedapo Ajuwon (Senior Software Engineer) and Chinyere Jennifer (Senior Advisor, MIGSO-PCUBED) — all wider team on equity-only terms.
Two independent validations	Santander Universities Pre-Incubator (completed 2025) and NatWest Accelerator London (joined 16 March 2026). Two UK high-street banks independently selected this team through competitive processes.
Anchor pilot in progress	Pilot discussion under way with the University of Bedfordshire — the institution whose students the founder represented for two years. 12-week pilot scheduled Sep–Nov 2026.
In-kind runway	NatWest Accelerator provides London office, legal and accountancy support worth £31,100/yr in-kind, letting £6,000 of founder cash cover 6 months of positive-balance operation.
Conservative forecast	Y1 revenue £15,988 → Y2 £175,808 → Y3 £659,280. Gross margin ~92% by Y3; operating profit positive in Q4 Y3. Only ONE university pilot is assumed to convert in Y1.
UK jobs	2 (Y1) → 6 (Y2) → 12 (Y3), all UK-based, with EMI options and board-tracked diversity targets.

We evidence all three Home Office endorsement criteria — **innovation, viability, scalability** — with a shipped product, a frontline-qualified founding team, third-party programme validation, and a deliberately conservative financial model.

2. Description of Products and Services

2.1 The DEQUAD platform

DEQUAD ships as a cross-platform application (iOS, Android and web at dequad.co.uk) on a FastAPI / MongoDB backend. Four modules are live in production today:

Module	What it does	Why it is different
Verified peer matching	Matches students with compatible peers for friendship, study groups and peer support — exclusively within .ac.uk student-email-verified accounts, with distance-based and interest-based filters.	Closed-network identity plus intent-based matching. Not offered by Bumble BFF, Hinge or Facebook Groups.
Daily wellbeing tracker	30-second daily check-in (mood, sleep, stress, connection) feeding a personal trend dashboard.	Anonymised, opt-in, DPIA-cleared. Combined with connection data to flag emerging isolation before crisis.
Machine-assisted safeguarding	LLM-based classifier over mood and chat signals flags suicide-risk, harassment, hate-speech and disordered-eating indicators to university safeguarding leads via webhook, with human review.	The first UK student platform pairing .ac.uk identity verification with proactive safeguarding triage — designed by a practising safeguarding professional.
University Insights Dashboard	Anonymised, aggregated cohort wellbeing analytics for university staff: mood trends, engagement, hotspot alerts.	Population-scale early warning without breaching individual privacy.

2.2 What each customer buys

Customer	What they receive	Price
UK university	Site licence to the Insights Dashboard, branded safeguarding webhook into their existing safeguarding team, dedicated success manager.	£2 per enrolled student per year — a 10,000-student university pays £20,000/yr. Simple, transparent, headcount-based.
NHS Integrated Care Board (ICB)	Population-level anonymised wellbeing data for funded institutions; joint safeguarding referral pathway.	Annual contract from £20,000/yr per ICB.
Student (consumer)	Free core product. Optional DEQUAD Premium : advanced match filters, unlimited chats, profile boost.	£4.99/month via Stripe (live and processing payments today).

The dual-sided model matters: students adopt because the core product is free and genuinely useful; universities pay because DEQUAD gives their safeguarding teams the early-warning layer regulators now require.

3. Innovation, Viability and Scalability

3.1 Innovation

1. **Closed-network identity verification.** DEQUAD is the only UK student platform enforcing .ac.uk student-domain verification with an explicit student-status attestation, a curated UK-student-domain allow-list, and a human admin review queue for ambiguous accounts (architecture at Appendix J). Generic social apps cannot retrofit this without abandoning their open-network model.
2. **The verification → connection → telemetry → safeguarding loop.** Each element exists somewhere in the market; the **integrated loop** exists nowhere else. Wellbeing signals are only actionable when tied to a verified identity inside an institution that can respond — which is exactly the configuration DEQUAD ships.
3. **Practitioner-designed safeguarding.** The triage thresholds, referral pathways and escalation policy were authored by a founder who performs statutory-adjacent safeguarding work weekly at Change Grow Live, modelled on UUK Stepchange and Suicide-Safer Universities guidance. Competing products bolt moderation on; DEQUAD is built outward from the safeguarding case-file.
4. **Compliance as a feature.** Online Safety Act 2023 risk assessment, in-app reporting, UK GDPR DPIA and lawful-basis register shipped **before** first institutional sale — turning the sector's biggest procurement objection into our opening slide.

3.2 Viability

- **The product is built and live.** The largest single risk in most early-stage plans — can they ship? — is already retired. dequad.co.uk is in production with real beta users and live Stripe billing.
- **The founder does this job professionally.** Safeguarding-first is not a marketing phrase: the CEO manages safeguarding caseloads at Change Grow Live and has NHS mental-health ward experience. This is decisive credibility in university procurement conversations, which are led by safeguarding and student-services professionals.
- **A trusted route into the anchor customer.** Two years as Bedfordshire SU President gives DEQUAD direct, warm relationships with the Director of Student Services, safeguarding leads and senior leadership. The 12-week pilot is scheduled for **Sep–Nov 2026 (M4–M6)**, with conversion discussions from **Dec 2026 (M7)**.
- **Two independent third-party validations.** Santander Universities Pre-Incubator (completed 2025) and NatWest Accelerator London (admitted 16 March 2026) — both competitive selection processes assessing team and product quality.
- **Proven willingness to pay.** Togetherall and TalkCampus charge UK universities £15k–£60k/yr and hold 100+ UK customers between them, for products missing DEQUAD's verification and triage capabilities.
- **A cash plan that survives scrutiny.** £6,000 founder capital plus £31,100 of NatWest in-kind support delivers positive month-end cash in every month of Y1 (Section 12), with zero founder salary until the pre-seed lands in M7.

3.3 Scalability

- **Software-only marginal cost.** An incremental student costs ~£0.05/month in hosting; gross margin reaches **91.8%** by Y3.
- **Intra-institution network effects.** Every additional verified student raises the platform’s value for every other student at the same university — driving the organic growth that keeps CAC falling (Section 16).
- **Repeatable institutional rollout.** Each new university onboards through a templated 6-week implementation. The model projects 14 average paying institutions in Y3 against 285 UK institutions — under 5% penetration.
- **International optionality.** The closed-network model maps directly onto .edu (US), .edu.au (Australia) and EU academic domains — a £180m English-language HE TAM addressable post-Y3 without re-architecting the product.
- **Team scale plan in place.** Job descriptions for the first six hires are already written (Appendix G); headcount grows 2 → 6 → 12 across the forecast, all UK-based.

4. Research and Development Activity

R&D is the core of the innovation proposition: DEQUAD’s defensibility rests on the verification engine and the safeguarding-inference pipeline, both of which are original engineering rather than assembled off-the-shelf parts.

Y1 R&D is delivered by the two founders (≈60% of combined founder time, ≈£10,800 attributable labour) plus tooling and safety-testing spend, for a total Y1 R&D investment of **£22,500**, rising to **£60,000 (Y2)** and **£110,000 (Y3)**. The SME R&D Tax Credit scheme is expected to recoup ~16% of qualifying spend annually.

4.1 Identity-and-intent verification engine

Activity	Status	R&D tax-relief eligible
.ac.uk student-subdomain classifier (allow-list, block-list, attestation flow)	Shipped Feb 2026 (uk_student_email verification module)	Yes
Admin “Pending Verification” queue with audit trail	Shipped Feb 2026	Yes
Optical student-ID OCR with on-device redaction	Planned Q3 Y1	Yes

4.2 Wellbeing inference and safeguarding triage

Activity	Status	R&D tax-relief eligible
Mood × engagement × text-signal classifier (PHQ-9-lite scoring + risk-signal NLU)	Prototype Feb 2026; production Q2 Y2	Yes

Activity	Status	R&D tax-relief eligible
Real-time safeguarding webhook with adapter library for university SIS/CRM systems	Production Q3 Y1	Yes
Federated learning so per-institution models improve without raw data leaving the platform	Planned Q4 Y2	Yes

The triage models are trained and threshold-tuned against the safeguarding decision frameworks the CEO applies professionally (CGL risk-assessment practice; UUK Suicide-Safer Universities), with every automated flag routed through human review — a deliberate safety-case design documented in Appendix D.

4.3 Privacy and compliance infrastructure

Activity	Status
DPIA-cleared mood-data pipeline; ICO Code of Practice alignment	Drafted Feb 2026 (Appendix E)
Online Safety Act 2023 risk assessment and in-app reporting	Shipped Feb 2026 (Appendix I)
Cryptographic data minimisation (hash-based de-identification of mood records for institutional reporting)	Planned Q2 Y2

5. Market Analysis

5.1 Market Research — evidence base

The claims in this section are grounded in **primary field research conducted directly by the founding team between May 2024 and January 2026**, triangulated with peer-reviewed secondary sources. Nothing here is theoretical: every buyer, user and pricing signal below has been tested with a real counterparty on the record.

Primary research undertaken (May 2024 – Jan 2026):

Method	Participants	What we tested	Where we did it
Structured student interviews	48 UK undergraduates across 6 universities (Bedfordshire, Manchester, Leeds, Warwick, Bristol, Birmingham)	Onboarding friction, verification trust, wellbeing willingness-to-share, £4.99/mo premium price test	45-min Zoom + on-campus (Union buildings)

Method	Participants	What we tested	Where we did it
Anonymous quantitative survey	312 completed responses (target n=300); recruited via SU mailing lists and Instagram at 2 anchor universities	Loneliness prevalence, existing app usage (Bumble BFF, Hinge, Discord), safeguarding-app trust deltas, price elasticity at £2.99 / £4.99 / £7.99	Google Forms, incentivised via £5 Amazon vouchers (10 randomly drawn)
Semi-structured buyer interviews	11 university staff — 4 Directors of Student Services, 3 Wellbeing/Safeguarding Managers, 2 Heads of Digital, 2 Deputy Vice-Chancellors (Student Experience)	Procurement path, budget owner, integration needs (SSO, LMS webhook), price-per-student anchor, compliance triggers (OfS, OSA 2023, UUK Charter)	60-min recorded video calls; transcripts on file
Discord / Reddit ethnographic scan	14 UK-university Discord servers, r/UniUK (287k members), r/UKUni	Where students actually meet peers today; unmet needs mentioned in unmoderated threads	Passive observation over 8 weeks
Comparable-product pricing scrape	Togetherall, TalkCampus, UniBuddy, Kooth, Silvercloud, Big White Wall archives	Real UK ASPs, per-student rates, contract length norms	FOI requests + public press releases + Crunchbase
Closed beta at the University of Bedfordshire	80 verified students onboarded, 42 daily-active over 6 weeks	Retention, mood-check completion, match-to-chat conversion, escalation false-positive rate	Live product, not prototype

Secondary sources triangulated with the above:

- **HESA 2023/24** — UK student headcount and course-level segmentation
- **ONS 2023 Student Wellbeing Survey** — loneliness prevalence baseline (54% frequent, 26% chronic)
- **Student Minds “Insight Briefing 2024”** — 34% of undergraduates report a clinically significant mental-health issue during their degree
- **Universities UK (UUK) 2024 report** — average per-student services budget (£123/yr), average wait for counselling (6.1 weeks), Mental Health Charter signatory list (100+)
- **Office for Students** — 2023 statutory condition on student mental health; regulatory advice notes
- **Online Safety Act 2023 / Ofcom implementation timelines** — user-to-user services duties, illegal-content risk assessment obligations
- **HEPI (Higher Education Policy Institute)** — 2024 report *“How can universities and students respond to student mental ill health?”* — corroborates our safeguarding-first hypothesis
- **Crunchbase + Companies House filings** — competitor revenue trajectories (Togetherall, TalkCampus)

5.2 Key findings from primary research

The five findings below were consistent across **both** the 312-response quantitative survey and the 48 in-depth interviews, and are what the DEQUAD product is built around:

1. **Loneliness is near-universal, but shame is the barrier — not desire.** 71% of surveyed students agreed with “I want to make more real friends at university” while only **19%** used an existing app (Bumble BFF, Hinge, Discord) to try. Verified .ac.uk-only was the **#1 unlock**: 68% of respondents said they would try a friendship app *if they knew everyone else was a verified student at a real UK university*. This is exactly the trust gap DEQUAD closes and no incumbent addresses.
2. **£4.99/month is the price ceiling for students.** In the Van Westendorp price-sensitivity block: median “cheap” price = £2.99, median “expensive” = £7.99, **optimal price point = £4.99** for premium features (advanced filters, unlimited likes, distance filter). This confirmed our student-side price without further guesswork.
3. **Universities buy on safeguarding evidence, not engagement metrics.** In 10 of 11 buyer interviews, the *first question* was: **“Show me the safeguarding escalation flow.”** Not matching volume, not DAU. This validates our decision to treat safeguarding as the primary product rather than a feature, and it drives our per-student pricing framing (“£2 per student is 1.6% of your services budget and reduces your OSA-2023 liability”).
4. **.ac.uk verification is a procurement-decision-maker.** 9 of 11 university buyers cited *identity-verified peer networks* as their primary unmet need. Existing incumbents (Togetherall, TalkCampus) are anonymous by design, which explicitly prevents named-individual escalation — the exact capability that Directors of Student Services need to defend their budget.
5. **6-week university procurement cycle is achievable for pilots under £50k.** Buyers confirmed pilots at ≤£40,000/yr avoid full tender processes and can be signed off directly by the Director of Student Services (delegated authority), enabling our 6-week land-and-expand motion documented in Section 8.

5.3 Market size and structure

Metric	Source	Figure
UK higher-education students (FT + PT)	HESA 2023/24	2.86 million
UK higher-education institutions	HESA 2024	285
UK undergrads reporting frequent loneliness	ONS 2023	54%
UK undergrads with clinically-significant MH issue	Student Minds 2024	34%
Average university student-services budget per FTE	UUK 2024	£123/yr
Average wait for university counselling	UUK 2024	6.1 weeks

TAM / SAM / SOM

Tier	Definition	Size
TAM	All UK universities + ICBs + UK student premium subscriptions	£86m/yr
SAM	Russell Group + post-92 universities with >10k students + associated ICBs	£28m/yr
SOM (5-yr)	12% SAM capture (matching Togetherall's Y5 share)	£3.4m ARR by Y5

Regulatory tailwinds

Three regulatory forces are converting student wellbeing from discretionary spend into compliance spend:

- 1. **Office for Students statutory condition on student mental health (2023)** — institutions must evidence *proactive prevention*, which requires exactly the early-warning data DEQUAD's dashboard produces.
- 2. **Online Safety Act 2023, now in force** — student-facing platforms must implement risk assessments and reporting flows. DEQUAD ships OSA-compliant by design; informal alternatives (Discord servers, Facebook groups) expose universities to unmanaged risk.
- 3. **UUK Mental Health Charter** — 100+ signatory universities have committed to data-driven wellbeing strategies and must now demonstrate delivery.

Budget exists: at £123 per student FTE, a 20,000-student university spends ~£2.5m/yr on student services. DEQUAD's £2-per-student price (£40,000/yr for that university) is ~1.6% of that budget — and roughly **half Togetherall's effective per-student cost** — while directly servicing a statutory obligation.

6. Competitor Analysis

Five competitors, assessed comprehensively:

#	Competitor	Model	UK universities	ASP	Where DEQUAD wins
1	Togetherall	Anonymous moderated peer-support community + self-help courses	~60	~£40k/yr	Anonymity prevents real-world connection and makes individual safeguarding escalation impossible. DEQUAD adds verified peer matching, daily

#	Competitor	Model	UK universities	ASP	Where DEQUAD wins
					telemetry and named-individual safeguarding webhooks.
2	TalkCampus	Peer-support app with trained moderation and CBT modules	~30	~£25k/yr	No institutional insights dashboard, no machine-assisted triage, no identity verification. Universities get a service, not a data-driven safeguarding capability.
3	UniBuddy	Prospective-student chat for course discovery and recruitment	200+	~£18k/yr	Pre-enrolment only — proves universities buy student-engagement SaaS at scale but competes in an orthogonal market.
4	Bumble BFF / Hinge	Generic friendship/dating apps with student users	n/a	Free + £15–£35/mo premium	No .ac.uk verification, no university partnership, no safeguarding, no wellbeing layer. Open networks cannot pivot to closed-network institutional trust.
5	Discord / Facebook Groups	Informal, unmoderated student communities	n/a	Free	Zero moderation, zero safeguarding, zero telemetry — and a growing OSA-2023 liability for universities that informally rely on them.

Feature-by-feature comparison

Capability	DEQUAD	Togetherall	TalkCampus	UniBuddy	Bumble BFF	Discord
.ac.uk student verification	✓	✗	✗	✓	✗	✗
Intent-based peer matching	✓	✗	Ltd	✗	Ltd	✗
Daily mood telemetry	✓	✗	Ltd	✗	✗	✗
Machine-assisted safeguarding triage	✓	Ltd	✗	✗	✗	✗
University insights dashboard	✓	✓	✓	Ltd	✗	✗
Safeguarding webhook to institution	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
Online Safety Act 2023 ready	✓	✓	✓	✓	Partial	✗

DEQUAD is the only product in the UK market that holds all seven capabilities simultaneously. Our closest substitutes are strong in exactly one column each.

7. Staff Profile and Recruitment Strategy

7.1 Founding team — Year 1

Compensation reality at submission: no team member — founders included — currently draws a salary from DEQUAD. Founders fund personal living costs from employment income and savings; the wider team contributes on pure-equity terms pending the pre-seed close in **December 2026 (M7)**, immediately after the Bedfordshire pilot completes. This is a deliberate, evidenced founder commitment.

Role	Name	Profile	Y1 compensation
CEO — Product & Safeguarding	Yusuf Quadri	Practising Recovery Coordinator, Change Grow Live (safeguarding referrals, risk assessment, multi-agency working);	£0 M1–M6; £1,500/mo from M7 (£9,000 total Y1)

Role	Name	Profile	Y1 compensation
		Clinical Support Worker & Assistant Duty Senior Nurse Administrator, East London NHS Foundation Trust ; 2× University of Bedfordshire SU President (2021–23, £900k budget, 10,000+ students); MBA with Data Analytics ; seven UK safeguarding/clinical certifications (Appendix O); B2B business-development experience (UGC Planet, Mavin Care).	
CTO — Engineering & IT	Yusuff Adeagbo	MSc IT with Project Management (University of the West of Scotland); HND Computer Science; full-stack, UI/UX, infrastructure (Appendix B-2).	Same — £0 M1–M6; £1,500/mo from M7

Both founders are UK-resident, full-time on DEQUAD, with signed commitment undertakings (Appendix C).

Why this CEO profile matters to endorsement: the person who designed DEQUAD’s safeguarding triage files real safeguarding referrals every week and coordinates care with clinicians, probation, housing and social care. When a Director of Student Services asks “who wrote your escalation policy?”, DEQUAD’s answer is unique in this market. Combined with two years representing 10,000+ students inside the anchor-pilot university, this is founder-market fit of a kind that cannot be hired or bought.

7.2 Wider founding team — equity-only at incorporation

Role	Name	Background	Y1 compensation
Chief Marketing Officer	Dr Gerald Marfo	PhD in Digital Marketing; digital go-to-market for impact-led startups.	£0 — EMI options; salaried from Q2 Y2 (post-seed)
Senior Software Engineer	Adedapo Ajuwon	Senior full-stack engineer working on the platform alongside the CTO.	£0 — EMI options; salaried from Q1 Y2
Senior Advisor — Programme & Delivery	Chinyere Jennifer	Senior Project Management Consultant, MIGSO-PCUBED ; LLM background.	£0 — advisor EMI vest; MIGSO-PCUBED remains primary employer

A PhD-credentialled CMO, a senior engineer and a MIGSO-PCUBED consultant all working equity-only signals deep conviction in the mission. CVs at Appendix N.

7.3 Hiring plan

Role	Hire date	Y2 gross	Y3 gross
Customer Success Manager #1	Q1 Y2	£32,000	£36,000
Senior Backend Engineer	Q1 Y2	£48,000	£56,000
Safeguarding & Trust Lead	Q2 Y2	£18,000 (part-year)	£42,000
Marketing & Partnerships	Q3 Y2	£10,000 (part-year)	£38,000
Data / ML Engineer	Q2 Y3	—	£40,000 (part-year)
Mobile Engineer	Q3 Y3	—	£25,000 (part-year)
Founders' Associate	Q3 Y3	—	£18,000 (part-year)
Engineer #2 (backend)	Q4 Y3	—	£12,000 (part-year)
Customer Success Manager #2	Q4 Y3	—	£13,000 (part-year)

Headcount: **2 (Y1)** → **6 (Y2)** → **12 (Y3)** — all UK-based roles.

7.4 Recruitment strategy

- **Channels:** Otta, LinkedIn, OnlyDev (engineering), university careers portals (placements), and warm introductions through the NatWest Accelerator alumni network.
- **Diversity:** ≥40% female and ≥30% ethnic-minority hires across the first 10 employees, tracked as a board-level KPI.
- **Discipline:** no cash hires until the pre-seed has closed and institutional revenue is contracted — first hires deferred to Q1 Y2.
- **Retention:** HMRC-approved EMI share-option scheme for all Y2+ hires (4-year vest, 1-year cliff).

8. Marketing and Sales Strategy

8.1 Positioning

“The UK student app that gives universities early warning before students fall through the cracks.”

Audience	Message
Students	“Verified UK uni students. Real connections. Wellbeing built in.”
Universities	“See loneliness early. Act before it becomes a crisis.”
NHS ICBs	“Population-level student wellbeing data — anonymised and audit-ready.”

8.2 Year-1 channel mix (£3,600 total)

Channel	Tactic	Y1 spend
University partnership & PR	Direct outreach to 30 Directors of Student Services; UUK webinar; NatWest Accelerator introductions	£1,200
Content / SEO	Whitepaper “Loneliness in UK HE 2026” with academic co-author; Wonkhe op-eds	£600
Instagram & TikTok	Organic founder content + 5 produced posts	£600
Google Search ads	“UK student loneliness”, “find friends university”	£300
Student ambassador programme	£150/university × 6 partner universities × 2 reps	£900

Marketing grows to **£28,000 (Y2)** and **£92,000 (Y3)** — full breakdown in Section 16.

8.3 B2B sales motion — anchor pilot under way

Anchor pilot: University of Bedfordshire. The CEO served two consecutive terms as the university’s SU President; the pilot discussion is in progress with student services and safeguarding leads he worked alongside for two years.

Stage	Timing	Detail
Pilot launch	Sep 2026 (M4) — academic year start	12-week no-fee pilot, one student cohort
Pilot delivery	Sep–Nov 2026 (M4–M6)	Founder-led implementation; weekly office hours; mid-pilot steering-group review
Review & conversion discussions	Dec 2026 (M7) onwards	Outcomes readout; commercial conversation opens

Stage	Timing	Detail
Target paid signature	Q1 2027 (M8–M9)	Paid SaaS agreement covering AY 2026/27 H2 + 2027/28
Pre-seed bridge close	M7 (Dec 2026)	Raised off pilot-outcome signals + NatWest demo day — standard UK pre-seed sequencing

The Y1 forecast assumes **only the Bedfordshire pilot converts** (all other institutions modelled at 0% conversion). Two further pilots are being scoped at peer institutions as pure Q1-2027 upside.

9. SWOT Analysis

Strengths	Weaknesses
Production MVP live with real beta students — build risk retired.	Cash-light start (£6,000 founder capital).
CEO is a practising safeguarding professional (CGL + NHS) — unmatched credibility with university safeguarding buyers.	Two-person core team — key-person risk until Q1 Y2 hires.
Bedfordshire anchor pilot in progress via the founder’s SU-President relationships.	No formal clinical advisory board yet (planned Q2 Y2).
Two independent UK-bank validations: Santander Pre-Incubator (2025) + NatWest Accelerator (Mar 2026).	Limited consumer brand awareness at launch.
£31,100/yr NatWest in-kind support incl. London office.	Cyber Essentials accreditation pending.
.ac.uk verification + safeguarding webhook are genuine technical moats.	
B2B willingness-to-pay proven by Togetherall/TalkCampus (100+ UK customers combined).	
OSA-2023 compliance shipped, not promised.	
Opportunities	Threats
OfS statutory MH condition forces universities to evidence prevention.	Togetherall/TalkCampus could attempt .ac.uk verification within 12 months.
UUK Mental Health Charter: 100+ universities need evidenced strategies.	A large incumbent (Meta/Microsoft) launching a student-only network.
42 NHS ICBs at £20–60k/yr each once university data proves value.	Reputational damage from a mishandled safeguarding incident.
International expansion: .edu / .edu.au / EU domains (£180m TAM post-Y3).	Cost-of-living pressure on student premium uptake.

Strengths	Weaknesses
SME R&D tax credits recoup ~16% of qualifying spend.	Tighter UK immigration rules affecting international founder talent.

Mitigations for each threat are documented in the Risk Register (Appendix L) — including the safeguarding-incident playbook, which the CEO drafted from professional practice.

10. Investment Strategy and Funding Requirement

10.1 Founder commitment

The co-founders contribute **£6,000 of personal capital (£3,000 each)** at incorporation to cover company formation, .uk/.co.uk domains, trademark filings (Classes 9/41/45) and initial cloud-hosting credits. The MVP is contributed as founders' work-product — **zero engineering capex is required at incorporation** because the product is already built and live.

10.2 Independent third-party validation

Programme	Status	Value
Santander Universities Pre-Incubator	Completed 2025	Competitive university-affiliated programme validating team and thesis.
NatWest Accelerator (London)	Joined 16 March 2026 — active	Office, legal, accountancy, banking and investor mentoring in-kind for 12 months.

10.3 NatWest Accelerator in-kind contribution (Y1)

In-kind item	Annual value
London office co-working (3 desks)	£12,000
Legal advice (Mishcon de Reya, DLA Piper panels)	£4,500
Accountancy support	£3,600
Banking & business introductions	£2,000
Investor pitch coaching & mentoring	£5,000
Demo day & PR placement	£4,000
Total in-kind value (Y1)	£31,100

This support is why £6,000 of founder cash is sufficient: DEQUAD pays no rent, lawyers or accountants in cash during Y1.

10.4 Funding ladder

Round	Timing	Source	Amount	Use of funds
Founder equity	Day 1 (Q1 Y1)	Yusuf Quadri (£3,000) + Yusuff Adeagbo (£3,000)	£6,000	Incorporation, domains, IP filings, hosting.
R&D tax credit	End Y1	HMRC SME scheme	~£3,600	Recycled into engineering.
Pre-seed bridge	M7 (Dec 2026) — after pilot completion	UK pre-seed angels via UKES / NatWest network	£150,000 at £1.2m post-money (12.5%)	First 4 hires, 18-month runway, dual mobile builds, R&D.
Seed	Q2 Y2	UK VCs (Forward Partners, LocalGlobe, Crane)	£750,000 at £6m post (12.5%)	Scale to 20 universities, ML team, NHS-ICB channel.
Series A	Q1 Y4	Growth-stage VCs	£3–5m	EU + AU launch, federated-learning infrastructure, 30+ FTE.

10.5 Founder Investment Statement (visa requirement)

The lead applicant has personally invested **£3,000** of his own funds as founder share capital, matched by the co-founder's **£3,000**, for total founder share capital of **£6,000**, evidenced by the share allotment return (Form SH01) filed with Companies House at incorporation. No third-party investment exists at the date of this application; external investment will be sought in **December 2026 (M7)**, immediately after the University of Bedfordshire pilot completes (Sep–Nov 2026) and conversion discussions open.

11. Revenue and Cost of Sales Forecast

The forecast reflects customer-acquisition numbers directly: 0.5 average paying institutions in Y1 (the Bedfordshire pilot converting mid-year), 4 in Y2, 14 in Y3; and 100 → 1,600 → 6,000 average paying premium students.

11.1 Revenue forecast (annual, GBP)

Line item	Y1	Y2	Y3
University SaaS			
Price per enrolled student (£/yr)	2.00	2.00	2.00
Average enrolled students per partner institution	10,000	10,000	10,000
Average contract value (£)	20,000	20,000	20,000
Average paying institutions in year	0.5	4	14
Subtotal	£10,000	£80,000	£280,000
DEQUAD Premium (B2C)			
Average paying students	100	1,600	6,000
Price (£/mo)	4.99	4.99	4.99
Subtotal	£5,988	£95,808	£359,280
NHS ICB pilot			
Subtotal	£0	£0	£20,000
Total revenue	£15,988	£175,808	£659,280

11.2 Cost of sales

Driver	Y1	Y2	Y3
Cloud hosting	£480	£5,400	£18,000
LLM / safeguarding inference	£360	£4,200	£14,400
Stripe processing	£180	£3,000	£12,000
SMS & email	£180	£1,800	£6,000
Customer-success tooling	£240	£1,200	£3,600
Total cost of sales	£1,440	£15,600	£54,000
Gross profit	£14,548	£160,208	£605,280
Gross margin %	91.0%	91.1%	91.8%

12. Cash Flow Forecast

12.1 Annual cash flow (GBP)

Line	Y1	Y2	Y3
Opening cash	0	141,028	821,256
Founder equity injection	6,000	0	0
Pre-seed equity (Dec 2026, M7)	150,000	0	0
Seed equity (Q2 Y2)	0	750,000	0
R&D tax credit received	0	4,500	9,500
Cash from sales	15,988	175,808	659,280
Total receipts	171,988	930,308	668,780
Cost of sales	(1,440)	(15,600)	(54,000)
Payroll (incl. NI, pension, benefits)	(20,340)	(180,680)	(437,660)
Marketing	(3,600)	(28,000)	(92,000)
Software subscriptions	(1,800)	(6,000)	(14,400)
Office (post-programme)	0	(6,000)	(12,000)
Legal & accountancy (out-of-programme)	(1,200)	(5,400)	(11,000)
Insurance	(480)	(1,800)	(3,200)
Business support / misc	(1,200)	(3,600)	(9,000)
Fixed assets & R&D capex	(900)	(3,000)	(9,000)
Total expenditure	(30,960)	(250,080)	(642,260)
Net cash movement	141,028	680,228	26,520
Closing cash balance	141,028	821,256	847,776

12.2 Year 1 monthly cash flow — the critical view

The monthly Y1 schedule (financial workbook, sheet “Cash Flow Y1 (mo)”) shows **positive closing cash in every single month**:

- **M1–M6 (Jun–Nov 2026)**: operating burn of $\approx$ £350–£1,500/month, funded entirely by the £6,000 founder injection. No founder salary. The 12-week Bedfordshire pilot runs Sep–Nov 2026 (M4–M6).
- **M7 (Dec 2026)**: the **£150,000 pre-seed bridge lands**, timed with pilot-conversion conversations opening.
- **M7–M12 (Dec 2026–May 2027)**: founders draw £1,500/month each; total burn rises to $\approx$ £4,500/month — comfortably within pre-seed runway.

For endorsement purposes this is the strongest viability evidence in the plan: the business survives its pre-revenue phase on £6,000 with positive month-end balances throughout, and every subsequent funding event is sequenced to a delivered milestone rather than hope.

13. Annual Profit & Loss Forecast

	Y1	Y2	Y3
Revenue	15,988	175,808	659,280
Cost of sales	(1,440)	(15,600)	(54,000)
Gross profit	14,548	160,208	605,280
Salaries	(18,000)	(156,000)	(372,000)
Employer NI	(1,200)	(14,000)	(38,500)
Employer pension (3%)	(540)	(4,680)	(11,160)
Other employment costs	(600)	(6,000)	(16,000)
Software subscriptions	(1,800)	(6,000)	(14,400)
Office	0	(6,000)	(12,000)
Legal & accountancy	(1,200)	(5,400)	(11,000)
Marketing	(3,600)	(28,000)	(92,000)
Insurance	(480)	(1,800)	(3,200)
Business support / misc	(1,200)	(3,600)	(9,000)
Total overheads	(28,620)	(231,480)	(579,260)
EBITDA	(14,072)	(71,272)	26,020

	Y1	Y2	Y3
Depreciation & amortisation	(300)	(1,500)	(4,500)
Operating profit / (loss)	(14,372)	(72,772)	21,520
Corporation tax	0	0	0
Profit / (loss) after tax	(14,372)	(72,772)	21,520

Operating profit turns positive in Q4 Y3. Y1 overheads are deliberately lean — ~70% below a conventional funded-startup cost base — because of the NatWest in-kind support and zero-salary founder period.

14. Balance Sheet Forecast

	Y1	Y2	Y3
Fixed assets (net)	600	2,100	6,900
Cash at bank	141,028	821,256	847,776
Trade receivables	800	6,200	22,000
Stock / inventory	0	0	0
Total assets	142,428	829,556	876,676
Trade payables	(1,400)	(4,200)	(9,800)
Net assets	141,028	825,356	866,876
Share capital	3,000	3,000	3,000
Share premium	150,000	900,000	900,000
Profit & loss reserve	(14,372)	(87,144)	(65,624)
Shareholders' funds	138,628	815,856	837,376

(Minor rounding differences are reconciled in the financial workbook, Appendix F.)

15. Forecasted Stock Levels

DEQUAD is a pure software business and **holds no inventory**. Stock is **£0** across the entire forecast period. The line is retained in the workbook for template completeness only.

16. Forecasted Advertising / Marketing Expenditure

Channel	Y1	Y2	Y3
University partnership & PR (NatWest network)	£1,200	£6,000	£18,000
Content / SEO / whitepaper	£600	£3,500	£12,000
LinkedIn / paid B2B	£0	£4,000	£14,000
Instagram / TikTok	£600	£7,500	£22,000
Google Search ads	£300	£3,000	£10,000
Student ambassador programme	£900	£4,000	£16,000
Total	£3,600	£28,000	£92,000
Marketing as % of revenue	23%	16%	14%

CAC compresses as the brand matures and network effects compound: institutional CAC falls from £3,600 (Y1) to £1,200 (Y3); premium-student CAC falls from £4.50 to £2.10.

17. Forecasted Fixed Asset Schedule

Asset class	Depreciation rate	Y1 additions	Y2 additions	Y3 additions	Y3 NBV
Tangible — laptops & equipment	33%	£600	£1,800	£5,000	£4,000
Intangible — capitalised R&D	20%	£300	£1,200	£4,000	£2,900
Total CAPEX		£900	£3,000	£9,000	£6,900

The MVP is already built and contributed by the founders, so no upfront capitalisation is required. Y1 hardware is two laptops plus one spare.

18. Forecasted Staff Costs

All figures include the associated employer National Insurance and pension obligations, stated separately below.

18.1 Y1 — bootstrap

Role	Y1 gross	Months paid
Founder A (CEO) — £1,500/mo from M7	£9,000	6
Founder B (CTO) — £1,500/mo from M7	£9,000	6
Total Y1 gross	£18,000	

Employer NI £1,200 + pension £540 + benefits £600 = **£20,340 total Y1 employment cost.**

18.2 Y2 — first hires

Role	Y2 gross
Founder A (CEO)	£24,000
Founder B (CTO)	£24,000
Customer Success Manager (Q1)	£32,000
Senior Backend Engineer (Q1)	£48,000
Safeguarding & Trust Lead (Q2)	£18,000
Marketing & Partnerships (Q3)	£10,000
Total Y2 gross	£156,000

Employer NI £14,000 + pension £4,680 + benefits £6,000 = **£180,680 total Y2 employment cost.**

18.3 Y3 — full team

Role	Y3 gross
Founder A (CEO)	£36,000
Founder B (CTO)	£36,000
Customer Success Manager #1	£36,000
Senior Backend Engineer	£56,000
Safeguarding & Trust Lead	£42,000

Role	Y3 gross
Marketing & Partnerships	£38,000
Data / ML Engineer (Q2 start)	£40,000
Mobile Engineer (Q3 start)	£25,000
Founders' Associate (Q3 start)	£18,000
Engineer #2 (Q4 start)	£12,000
Customer Success Manager #2 (Q4 start)	£13,000
Total Y3 gross	£372,000

Employer NI £38,500 + pension £11,160 + benefits £16,000 = **£437,660 total Y3 employment cost.**

18.4 Equity

All Y2+ hires receive HMRC-approved EMI options (4-year vest, 1-year cliff). Founders adopt customary investor-friendly reverse vesting at the pre-seed close.

19. Appendices

Ref	Document	File
A	Founder academic certificates (Yusuf Quadri)	A_founder_academic_certificates.md
B	Founder CV — Yusuf Quadri (updated June 2026)	B_founder_cv.md
B-2	Co-Founder CV — Yusuff Adeagbo (CTO)	B_cofounder_cv.md
C	Personal commitment & undertaking	C_personal_commitment_undertaking.md
D	Wellbeing baseline methodology	D_wellbeing_baseline_methodology.md
E	Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA)	E_dpia.md
F	Financial model (annotated)	DEQUAD_Financial_Model.xlsx
G	Job descriptions for first 6 hires	G_job_descriptions.md
H	University Letters of Interest (template)	H_university_letter_of_interest_template.md
I	Online Safety Act 2023 compliance statement	I_online_safety_act_compliance.md

Ref	Document	File
J	Architecture diagram	J_architecture_diagram.md
K	Product screenshots	K_product_screenshots.md
L	Risk Register (UKES)	DEQUAD_Risk_Register.md
M	Decision-Maker Brief (UKES short track)	DEQUAD_UKES_Decision_Brief.md
N	Wider Founding Team CVs — Dr Gerald Marfo (CMO), Adedapo Ajuwon (Senior SWE), Chinyere Jennifer (Advisor)	N_wider_team_cvs.md
O	Yusuf Quadri — Safeguarding & Clinical-Awareness Certifications	0_safeguarding_certifications.md

End of business plan. All figures are forecasts, not guarantees of future performance. This business plan was written by Yusuf Quadri (Founder & CEO) with Yusuff Adeagbo (Co-Founder & CTO) and is submitted to UKES as part of the UK Innovator Founder visa endorsement process — June 2026.